Modi protégé, got the prestigious human resource development (HRD) portfolio, enough to spark off private criticism from others who felt left out. There was even a suggestion that Modi had elevated Smriti because he wanted to send out a message to Sushma that she wasn't the only woman face of the BJP. Piyush Goyal, who had starred in the campaign, was given an integrated energy portfolio (coal and power) while Gadkari had to be content with surface transport. 'All road contractors from Maharashtra will now be heading to Delhi!' was the joke in Delhi's power corridors on Gadkari's appointment.

Advani and the old guard were, yet again, not obliged. The BJP patriarch had been pushing for a constitutional post—'Make me the Lok Sabha Speaker' was his plea. Modi put his foot down—the tears in Parliament's central hall were replaced by the chilling pragmatism of power. A decision was taken that no one above the age of seventy-five years would be given a ministership. 'We can always make them governors if they wish,' Modi told an aide (eventually, Advani and Dr Murli Manohar Joshi were even removed from the BJP parliamentary board).

The allies were put in their place as well. Ram Vilas Paswan had been hoping for a 'wet' ATM ministry—he was given the relatively lower profile consumer affairs ministry. 'Paswan's past meant that the prime minister was suspicious of him—he doesn't want anyone in the government who will affect his clean image,' a Cabinet colleague later told me. The Shiv Sena, too, asked for more—but it had to be content with the heavy industries ministry. Modi wanted to send out a clear message that he was the Big Boss—this wasn't a UPA-II-like government where allies could decide ministries. And he certainly wasn't going to be bullied like a timid Manmohan Singh. The only demand he acceded to was from Rajasthan Chief Minister Vasundhara Raje who was peeved that no minister from her state was in the original list despite the BJP sweeping the state; thus, Nihalchand Meghwal was made a minister of state.

Left out of the government was Arun Shourie, one of the finest minds from the political right, who had openly backed Modi's prime ministership. A few days before the Cabinet formation, I had interviewed Shourie and got